RUSSIAN NAPOLEON CAKE

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	REST	TOTAL TIME
1 cake, 20 cm, 8 to 10 servings	**1 h 30 min**	**2 h chilled, up to overnight**	**about 5 h**

OVEN
375F for 7-8 min per sheet

INGREDIENTS

2 batches	Flaky tart dough
2 batches	Pastry cream
480 ml	Heavy cream, very cold
4 tsp	Sugar, for the whipped cream
600 g	Berries, for serving
1 to 2 tbsp	Sugar, for the berries
quantity not given	Lemon juice, fresh, for the berries

METHOD

1. Make two batches of flaky tart dough and two batches of pastry cream. Both need to be cold before the cake goes together.
2. Heat the oven to 375F. Line four baking sheets with parchment and have four more sheet pans standing by to weight the dough.
3. Working in batches, roll the dough out to ten rounds of 20 cm, each one 2 mm thick.
4. Lay two rounds on each lined sheet. Cover them with a second sheet of parchment and set a sheet pan on top as a weight.
5. Bake 4 minutes. Pull the sheet out, press gently down on the weight and the dough, and turn the sheet round.
6. Bake a further 3 to 4 minutes, to a light gold. If they are still too pale, take the weight and parchment off and keep baking.
7. Cool the rounds completely on a baking rack.
8. Crumble two of the cooled rounds and keep the crumbs aside for the outside of the cake.
9. Set one round on a cardboard cake round or a plate. Spread pastry cream over it with an offset spatula, out to the edge and a shade under 6 mm thick.
10. Carry on stacking and spreading until eight rounds are in place. Leave the eighth bare, because that is the top of the cake.
11. Whisk the heavy cream with the sugar on medium speed in a stand mixer fitted with the whisk, to medium peaks.
12. Cover the top of the cake with the whipped cream and spread it with a spatula. Push the surplus gently over the edges and work it evenly down the sides.
13. Press handfuls of the crumbled rounds onto the cream until the whole cake is coated.
14. Refrigerate at least 2 hours, and up to overnight, until it is cold and set right through.
15. For the fruit, toss the berries with sugar to the sweetness you want and sharpen them with a squeeze of lemon.
16. Cut the cake into slices and spoon the berries over, if you are serving them.

NOTES

Ten rounds get baked. Eight go into the stack and two are crumbled for the coating.
The second sheet of parchment and the sheet pan on top are what hold the flaky dough flat instead of letting it puff.
Two batches of pastry cream come to roughly 1 L, which is what eight layers at just under 6 mm take.
An overnight chill softens and melds the layers into the traditional texture. Served within about three hours of assembly the layers instead stay crisp and separate.
The cake is at its best within 24 hours of baking.

DOUGH

Flaky Tart Dough

Makes: 2 tart or pie shells, 23 or 25 cm, or 12 tartlet shells at 10 cm / Active Time: 25 min / Rest: 2 h chilled minimum or overnight, then 30 min to 1 h once lined / Total Time: 3 h 30 min to 4 h / Oven: 375F / 190C, about 20 min partially baked or 30 min fully baked

INGREDIENTS

1 tsp	Salt
150 ml	Water, very cold
455 g	All-purpose flour
300 g	Unsalted butter, very cold

METHOD

1. Stir the salt into the cold water until it dissolves. Keep the bowl refrigerated until you need it.
2. Cut the butter into 2.5 cm pieces.
3. Using a food processor, weigh the flour into the processor bowl and scatter the butter across the top. Pulse briefly, stopping at coarse crumbs with plenty of butter still at pea size. Pour in the salted water and pulse a few seconds more, until the dough is clumping toward a ball but is still rough and you can see chunks of butter in it.
4. Working by hand, weigh the flour into a mixing bowl and scatter the butter over the top, then cut it in with a pastry blender or two knives to the same coarse crumb, leaving pea-size butter. Drizzle the salted water over and stir with a fork to a shaggy mass, then bring it gently together into a ball. Stop while it is still rough with butter showing.
5. Split the dough in two on a lightly floured bench and pat each half into a disk 2.5 cm thick. Wrap tightly and chill at least 2 hours, or overnight.
6. To line a pan, roll a disk out to 3 mm on a lightly floured surface, working from the middle outward in every direction. Lift the sheet and swing it a quarter turn every few passes, dust underneath whenever it grabs, and move fast so the butter stays cold.
7. For a pie dish, cut a circle 5 cm wider than the dish. For a tart pan with a removable base, cut it 4 cm wider.
8. Fold the round in half or into quarters to carry it, lay it in the pan, settle it into the bottom and up the sides, and press it home gently. Trim it flush with the rim using a sharp knife.
9. In a pie dish you can instead leave a 12 mm overhang, fold it under itself and crimp or flute the edge. The bakery leaves the edge plain.
10. A shell that goes into the oven unbaked only needs refrigerating until you use it, covered with plastic wrap if that is overnight.
11. A shell you intend to blind bake has to be chilled firm to the touch first, 30 minutes to 1 hour. This is what buys you the flakiest crust.
12. Heat the oven to 375F. Line the chilled shell with parchment paper and fill it with pie weights.
13. For a partially baked shell, give it about 20 minutes, until the surface is dry and pale with no damp opaque patches left. Lift a corner of the paper to check. Lift out the weights and paper and return the shell for a few minutes more.
14. Watch the base while it bakes. If it domes up, pierce it with the tip of a knife, keeping the hole small if a very liquid filling is going in.
15. For a fully baked shell, run about 25 minutes under the weights, until the surface is light brown. Take out the weights and paper and bake 5 minutes more, to golden brown.
16. Cool the shells completely on wire racks before filling them.

NOTES

455 g flour to 300 g butter to 150 ml water is the 3:2:1 ratio by weight the dough is built on, so it scales up and down directly.
The pea-size butter is the whole point. Rolled out, the sheet should show faint streaks of butter.
Chilling before the bake sets pockets of flour and water around each piece of butter. Those pockets survive the oven and give the fork-tender texture.
For the einkorn version, replace the all-purpose flour with equal parts pastry flour and einkorn flour.
Tartine also mixes this dough by a longer method that comes out closer to rough puff. That version is the one used for galettes.

FILLING

Pastry Cream

Makes: 600 ml / Active Time: 25 min / Rest: 10 min off the heat, then chilled / Total Time: 40 min plus chilling

INGREDIENTS

480 ml	Whole milk
1/2 bean	Vanilla bean
1/4 tsp	Salt
115 g	Sugar
30 to 35 g	Cornstarch
2	Eggs, large
60 g	Unsalted butter

METHOD

1. Set a bowl on the counter and rest a fine-mesh sieve in its rim. The cream lands there later, so it needs to be ready before anything goes on the heat.
2. Measure the milk into a heavy saucepan, anything but aluminium. Split the half bean lengthwise, scrape the seeds out with the tip of a knife straight into the milk, and add the salt.
3. Bring the milk up over medium-high heat to just short of boiling. Stir every so often and sweep the base of the pan, because the solids settle there and scorch. A bigger batch needs more attention.
4. Meanwhile whisk the sugar and cornstarch together in a mixing bowl. Take the full 35 g of cornstarch for a firm cream that holds a cut slice, and 30 g for everything else.
5. Break the eggs in and whisk until no lumps remain.
6. Ladle roughly a third of the scalding milk into the eggs in a slow stream, whisking the whole time. A lightly damp towel under the bowl steadies it and frees both hands.
7. Return it to the remaining milk on the stove. Whisk over a medium flame for roughly 2 minutes, until the body matches softly whipped cream.
8. Bring it just to the edge of a boil so the starch cooks out fully. A few slow bubbles breaking the surface is the target. A hard boil will curdle it.
9. Take the pan off the heat at once and push the cream through the sieve into the waiting bowl. Left sitting in the hot pan it keeps cooking.
10. Give it 10 minutes to drop in temperature, stirring now and then so heat escapes and no skin sets on top.
11. Cut the butter into four pieces. At around 60C, whisk them in one at a time, each piece disappearing completely before the next goes in.
12. Press plastic wrap flat against the surface of the cream and refrigerate. To cool it fast, spread it in a shallow dish first and wrap it the same way.

NOTES

Never use an aluminium pan. The yolks react with the metal and the cream turns grey.
Scorched milk ruins the whole batch and cannot be rescued. If dark spots appear on the pan bottom, taste the milk and start over if it has gone acrid.
The gap between properly thick and curdled is a matter of seconds. A cream that has gone only slightly grainy will sometimes come back with an immersion or countertop blender, though not reliably.
Two whole eggs give a lighter cream than the all-yolk French versions. Four yolks in place of the eggs makes a richer one.
Whisking the cream once it is cold breaks the starch down and thins it, so handle it gently from then on. Well covered, it keeps 5 days in the refrigerator.

DATE ____ / ____ / ____ RATING ____ / 5 OVEN ADJ _____

NOTES _____

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